were valued at a mere 20% when compared to those in the United States; by 2005, that figure jumped to 40%, and today, they are on a par with their rival. In 1978, only 9.8% of the economy was derived from international trade, while that figure currently stands at 65%. These transformations have completely disrupted the country's internal economy. The weight of the agricultural sector has fallen precipitously, services have expanded, and industry has become the motor force driving all economic activity.[1]

This new Asian power has sustained lofty growth rates during three complex moments along its course: the periphery's 'lost decades', the collapse of the Soviet bloc, and the recent global crisis. Throughout each of these stages, China has ploughed ahead in a historical transformation comparable to the steam revolution in England, industrialisation in the United States, and development in the Soviet Union. China's new gravitational pull has been confirmed over the last six years. Its support for the dollar and euro at the height of the crisis prevented the 2009 recession from becoming a global depression. Financial aid from Beijing was decisive in the initial rescue of US mortgage institutions, the subsequent support of bonds and treasuries, and the recent propping up of the European currency. The magnitude of savings accumulated by China underscores the dimensions of this rescue. This support was not a philanthropic act. It served to assure the continuity of its exports and avoid the devaluation of the enormous quantity of assets it has amassed in foreign currency. But the real novelty of the situation is the country's gravitational pull. In the 1970s it would have been inconceivable that the international financial system could be saved by China.

The mutation of this economy began in 1978 and, until 2007, was centred on rural emigration and an increase in productivity outpacing wage growth. This combination opened the door to the turn to exports and the capture of an increasing portion of the world market. However, this expansion was not without its costs. Wages and overall consumption fell as a proportion of total income. The export boom flourished alongside profits, giving rise to an internal social breach. China's rise illustrated the expanse in which accumulation could bloom in a continent-sized, underdeveloped economy. Yet it is also worth noting that China was not starting from zero. The aggregate value of its industry in 1980 was already much greater than Brazil's; India's remained abysmally far behind (Dic and Zhang 2011).

The crisis, in turn, tended to reinforce a turn towards greater consumption. An attempt was made to reduce dependency on the export of basic manufactured goods and to expand the internal market. With these aims in mind, various Keynesian plans to stimulate demand were introduced. But the results of the